Which Dutch supermarket is the cheapest?

Comparing the six largest chains,
November 2022 – October 2026

Jaimy Hereygers
I6285837

Code: `https://github.com/jhereygersstudent/Mat2007`

MAT2007 Introduction to Programming
Maastricht Science Programme, Maastricht University

October 2026

Introduction

Groceries in the Netherlands have become noticeably more expensive in recent years, while almost every supermarket advertises itself as the cheapest option. Discounters such as Dirk, Lidl and Aldi build their image on low prices, while Albert Heijn and Jumbo promise to match them with special offers.

This report addresses a simple question: **Which of the six largest Dutch supermarket chains offered the cheapest everyday shopping basket between November 2022 and October 2026, and did the ranking change over time?**

To answer this, public price data from the price-comparison site *checkjebon.nl*[1] are analysed in R; the code is available on GitHub [2].

Data sample

The dataset contains the daily online product lists of Dutch supermarkets, archived on GitHub [1]. The first snapshot of every month from November 2022 to October 2026 was used (48 snapshots, about 3.1 million prices), for Albert Heijn, Jumbo, Lidl, Plus, Aldi and Dirk. Lidl only appears from December 2025. The relevant fields are:

- `n`: product name
- `p`: price in euro
- `s`: pack size (e.g. `1 l`, `500 g`)

The data required cleaning: pack sizes were converted to grams, millilitres or pieces, and for each of 30 everyday products (milk, eggs, cheese, pasta, oats, coffee, ...) the cheapest matching product per chain and month was selected. Each price was divided by the median price of that item across the six chains, and the mean of these ratios gives the chain's price level. Months without data repeat the previous month.

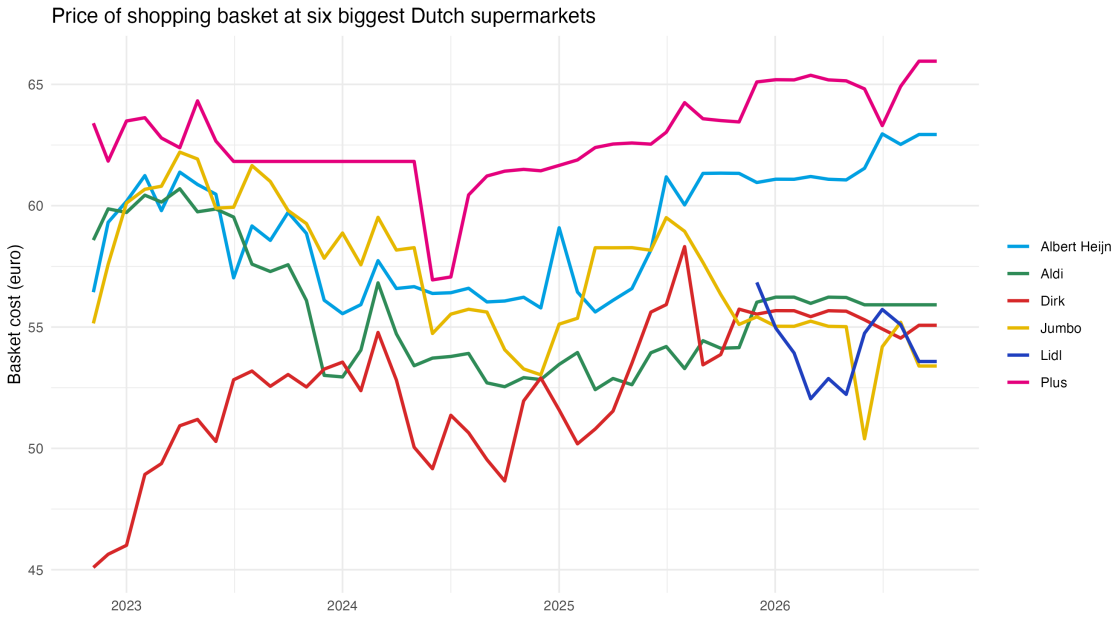


Figure 1: Cost of the 30-item basket per supermarket chain and month, November 2022 – October 2026.

Results and discussion

Figure 1 shows the shopping basket cost of each chain over time. Dirk had the lowest overall price and came out on top in 30 of the 48 months, with a price about 7.5% under the average of the group. Lidl's prices looked almost the same when it was there, but unfortunately the data was only available for eleven months, so its result is less certain. Aldi was a bit behind them and was the cheapest in 8 months, mostly in 2024 and 2025. Albert Heijn (+1.8%) and Jumbo (+2.7%) were only slightly over the average, and neither of them was the cheapest for long. Plus always had the most expensive groceries by quite a bit:

$$\Delta_{\text{Dirk}} = -7.5\%, \quad \Delta_{\text{Lidl}} = -6.6\%, \quad \Delta_{\text{Aldi}} = -3.3\%, \quad \Delta_{\text{AH}} = +1.8\%, \quad \Delta_{\text{Jumbo}} = +2.7\%, \quad \Delta_{\text{Plus}} = +9.3\%$$

[1] `https://www.checkjebon.nl`

In euros, the average basket of the six chains cost about €57.40 in late 2022 and €58.40 in 2026. A shopper at Plus paid around €10 more for the same basket than a shopper at Dirk or Lidl.

Over time the gap between the supermarkets got smaller. Early on Dirk took the lead, with 19% below average in late 2022, but this shrank every year: to 12% in 2023, 7.5% in 2024, 6% in 2025 and around 4% in 2026. Jumbo moved the other way, from 5% above average in 2023 to 5% below in 2026. Because of this, Lidl and Jumbo traded places near the bottom more often in the last year: Lidl was the cheapest in 5 months of 2026, Jumbo in 4 and Dirk in only 1. Figure 2 shows the spread of the monthly differences per chain.



Figure 2: Monthly difference of each chain's basket to the average of the six chains. Grey dots are single months, the large dot is the median.

The spread is very different per chain. Plus and Dirk stayed on the same side of the average almost every month. Jumbo has the widest spread, it goes from about 3% below to 5% above average in the middle half of the months, which fits with its prices changing the most over the four years.

It seems like the bigger chains started closing in on the discounters, which makes sense because they are trying to keep customers. When one store lowers their prices, the others have to follow. Dirk's basket became about 20% more expensive between 2022 and 2026, while Jumbo's and Aldi's became a bit cheaper, so the discounters lost part of their advantage.

The data also has some limitations. Some parts of the data stayed flat for long stretches because prices were not updated, which maybe made the 2026 numbers for Lidl and Jumbo look a little better than they really were, since Albert Heijn and Dirk were rarely updated that year. Products were matched by name, so a product is not always exactly the same at every chain. Offers and loyalty prices like "bonus" were left out, so the actual cost for shoppers could be different when this is taken into account. Finally, the basket always picks the cheapest version of a product, so it is good for comparing chains but does not show the real inflation of groceries. Still, the overall order stayed fairly steady, with the three discounters scoring low and Plus at the top every single month.

References

[1] Checkjebon.nl. *Supermarket price data*. Available at: `https://github.com/supermarkt/checkjebon` (accessed October 2026).

[2] J. Hereygers. *MAT2007 final project: R code and README*. Available at: `https://github.com/jhereygersstudent/Mat2007`.